BRAIN 06

Modafinil

Wakefulness-promoting drug taken by mouth; a 50:50 mix of R and S mirror-image forms



CLASS	STUDIED FOR	HUMAN EVIDENCE	US STATUS
Wakefulness-promoting agent	Sleepiness: narcolepsy, OSA, shift work	Large trials; FDA approved	FDA approved (Provigil) · Schedule IV

STUDIED FOR

Narcolepsy — HUMAN	Sleep apnea sleepiness — HUMAN	Shift work disorder — HUMAN
Focus, healthy adults — HUMAN	Fatigue (MS, cancer) — HUMAN	

HOW IT WORKS IN THE BODY

Modafinil ▶ Dopamine carrier ▶ More dopamine ▶ Wakefulness

- **Label:** how it promotes wakefulness is unknown
- **In lab studies,** binds the dopamine reuptake site; raises dopamine outside cells
- Effects resemble **stimulants** such as amphetamine, but the profile is not identical
- The **R form** is sold on its own as armodafinil (Nuvigil)

EVIDENCE & WHAT'S KNOWN

EVIDENCE

FDA APPROVED
LEVEL 5 OF 5

- Placebo trials in narcolepsy, OSA, shift work
- FDA approved 1998 (Provigil)
- EU and UK: narcolepsy only since 2010

NOT YET ESTABLISHED

- Use in children (not approved)
- Pregnancy (birth defect signal)

QUICK PRACTICAL INFO

HALF-LIFE: About 15 hours after repeated doses (label)	ROUTES STUDIED: Oral tablets (label)
PHARMACOKINETICS: Peak in 2 to 4 hours; steady state in 2 to 4 days	SOLD AS: Prescription tablets (Provigil); Schedule IV
MONITORED IN TRIALS: Rash; psychiatric symptoms; blood pressure, heart	SPORT (WADA): Prohibited in competition, class S6

REGULATORY

FDA	Approved (Provigil, 1998)
DEA	Schedule IV controlled substance
EMA	Restricted to narcolepsy (2010 review)
WADA	Prohibited in competition (S6.A)

REFERENCES

1. FDA (DailyMed), Provigil prescribing information, Mar 2025
2. EMA, modafinil referral (Article 31), Nov 2010
3. WADA, 2026 Prohibited List

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